

Honorable Seth Grove, Chair State Government Committee House of Representatives P.O. Box 202196
State Capitol Building Harrisburg, PA 17102

October 13, 2021

Dear Chairman Grove and other members of the committee:

On behalf of the Pennsylvania Chapter of the National Association of Social Workers (NASW-PA), we thank you for the opportunity to participate in the 2021 Pennsylvania Congressional Redistricting Process. NASW-PA has just over 4,000 members who provide a range of crucial services across the Commonwealth, including but not limited to: connecting individuals to social service resources, individual and family therapy, policy analysis, community organizing and research. This range of experiences and our profession's Code of Ethics informed our 2021 Legislative Agenda, adopted by our Board of Directors. A key component of this agenda is our commitment to end partisan gerrymandering. NASW-PA supports efforts to improve representation for all Pennsylvanians through fair, independent legislative redistricting that is designed on a non-partisan basis and will lead to a General Assembly that is more responsive to the needs of all residents of Pennsylvania.

We are appreciative that your committee has provided the opportunity for the public to be heard through these public hearings and to submit maps that meet the requirements of maintaining communities of interest in the same district. As you are aware, Congressional Districts are vital to ensuring the voices and experiences of all Pennsylvanians are represented in Congress and that federal money is allotted to districts based on their need. A transparent process that maintains communities of interest is vital in promoting trust and participation in our government, which is crucial for all of us, but especially our most vulnerable residents. This year, Pennsylvania will be losing a Congressional seat, elevating the importance of a transparent redistricting process.

As you know, on August 24 of this year, the Pennsylvania Legislative Reapportionment Commission voted to end the practice of counting prisoners as residents of the prison rather than their last known residential address. We encourage your committee to adopt this same practice when drawing the lines for our Congressional districts. Individuals who are incarcerated disproportionately come from under-resourced communities. Counting prisoners as residents of their last known address will increase the flow of federal resources to these communities, an important step in addressing the inequities of our criminal legal system.

We also embrace these important values in your deliberations:

- Continue to operate with transparency and embrace maximum public input
- Follow the same principles for drawing Congressional District lines as those set forth in the PA Constitution for state legislative districts:
 - o Districts must be composed of compact and contiguous territory as nearly equal in population as practicable
 - o Unless absolutely necessary no county, city, incorporated town, borough, township or ward shall be divided
- Heed the recommendations of the 2019 PA Redistricting Reform Commission to:

- o Protect racial and language minorities against discrimination - prohibit packing and cracking
 - o Outlaw district plans designed to protect incumbents or discriminate against political parties.
- In order to achieve this, in drawing these maps the commission should not consider addresses of any individual, political affiliation of registered voters and previous election results, unless required by Federal law.

We look forward to supporting you in the process. Sincerely,

Kristie Jo King, LSW, CDP

NASW-PA President

NASW-PA

Johanna Byrd, ACSW, CAE, IOM

Executive Director